Government and society

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Government and society: who decides? (186 words)

A modern state is judged by how well it looks after its citizens. A **citizen** expects roads and railways, so a country with poor **infrastructure** soon **falls behind** its neighbours. Governments raise money through **taxation** and decide how **public spending** is divided between schools, hospitals and defence. A well-designed **subsidy** can protect a vital industry, while strict **regulation** protects consumers from unsafe goods.

Social problems, however, are harder to solve than economic ones. Persistent **poverty** and growing **inequality** test the **welfare** system, and **discrimination** in the workplace still prevents some groups from **getting ahead**. Every **policy** reflects a choice: lower taxes now, or better services later? New **legislation** sets the rules, but **corruption** can destroy public trust in any system.

Societies also change shape. An **ageing population** means higher pension costs, while **immigrant** workers fill gaps in the labour market and enrich culture. A **volunteer** or a **charity** often fills the space the state leaves empty, and shared activities help to build **social cohesion**. At every **election**, voters judge whether the balance feels right. The long-term goal of **sustainable development** requires leaders to think beyond the next vote.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
falls behind	loses ground to
getting ahead	being successful

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
legislation	n	laws made by a government	*New legislation protects workers.*
taxation	n	the system of collecting taxes	*Higher taxation could fund healthcare.*
public spending	n	money the government spends	*Public spending on transport should increase.*
subsidy	n	money given by the government to help an industry	*Farmers receive a subsidy for fuel.*
welfare	n	support for people in need	*The welfare system helps the unemployed.*

inequality	n	unfair difference between groups	*Income inequality is growing.*
poverty	n	the state of being very poor	*Poverty limits children's opportunities.*
infrastructure	n	roads, railways and basic services	*Poor infrastructure slows development.*
policy	n	a plan of action by a government	*The policy aims to reduce traffic.*
regulation	n	an official rule	*Stricter regulation protects consumers.*
citizen	n	a person who belongs to a country	*Every citizen has the right to vote.*
volunteer	n	a person who works without pay	*Volunteers help in many local projects.*
charity	n	an organization that helps people in need	*The charity raised money for flood victims.*
immigrant	n	a person who moves to another country to live	*Immigrants contribute to the economy.*
ageing population	n	a society with more and more old people	*An ageing population means higher pension costs.*
social cohesion	n	how well people in a society get along	*Shared activities build social cohesion.*
discrimination	n	unfair treatment of a group	*Laws prohibit discrimination at work.*
election	n	a vote to choose leaders	*Turnout in the election was low.*
corruption	n	dishonest behavior by powerful people	*Corruption damages trust in government.*
sustainable development	n	growth that does not harm the future	*Sustainable development needs long-term planning.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
offender	n	a person who commits a crime
deterrent	n	something that stops people doing wrong
rehabilitation	n	helping a criminal to return to normal life
sentence	n	the punishment given by a court
fine	n	money paid as a punishment
community service	n	unpaid work done as punishment
reoffend	v	to commit another crime
burglary	n	breaking into a building to steal
law enforcement	n	the work of police and courts
witness	n	a person who sees a crime

Practice: fill the gaps

welfare · subsidy · regulation · poverty · immigrant · inequality · citizen · election

1. The _____ system helps the unemployed.
2. Farmers receive a _____ for fuel.
3. Stricter _____ protects consumers.
4. _____ limits children's opportunities.
5. _____ contribute to the economy.
6. Income _____ is growing.
7. Every _____ has the right to vote.
8. Turnout in the _____ was low.

More words on this topic **(not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)**

authority (n): the power to give orders
bureaucracy (n): complicated official rules
campaign (n): a planned set of actions to achieve a goal
civil rights (n): the rights of every citizen
coalition (n): a government of several parties
constitution (n): the basic laws of a country
council (n): a local governing group
democracy (n): government by the people
dictatorship (n): rule by one person
equality (n): the same rights for all
fund (v): to provide money for
healthcare system (n): the services that look after the sick
homeless (adj): having no home
housing benefit (n): money to help pay for housing
human rights (n): basic rights of all people
income tax (n): tax on money earned
law and order (n): safety and respect for the law
local authority (n): the government of a local area
minimum wage (n): the lowest pay allowed by law
parliament (n): the body that makes laws
political party (n): a group with shared political aims
pension (n): money paid to retired people
public service (n): a service provided by the government
social class (n): a group in society by wealth
social security (n): government help for those in need
standard of living (n): the level of comfort in life
state-funded (adj): paid for by the government
tax evasion (n): illegally avoiding tax
voter (n): a person who votes
welfare state (n): a system of government support

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people think governments should spend money on public transport rather than roads. To what extent do you agree?
2. The gap between rich and poor is increasing. What problems does this cause and what can be done?
3. Some people believe taxes should be higher so governments can pay for more services. Discuss both views.
4. Volunteering should be compulsory for young people. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Public transport reduces traffic and pollution and helps people without cars.
- **Against / bad:** Roads are essential for freight and emergency services.
- **For / good:** Higher taxes can pay for health, education and welfare that protect the vulnerable.
- **Against / bad:** High taxes may reduce incentives to work and invest.
- **For / good:** Volunteering teaches responsibility and builds social cohesion.
- **Against / bad:** Forced volunteering is a contradiction and may breed resentment.

Speaking

Part 1

- Do you vote or want to vote?
- Do you follow the news?
- Do you volunteer?
- What do you think about your local area's services?
- Would you like to be a politician?

Part 3

- What should the government spend more on?
- Should everyone have to vote?
- How can the gap between rich and poor be reduced?
- Do charities do a better job than governments?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a public place or service you use often. You should say: what it is, where it is, how you use it, and explain why it is important.

Answers

1. welfare (welfare)
2. subsidy (subsidy)
3. regulation (regulation)
4. Poverty (poverty)
5. Immigrants (immigrant)
6. inequality (inequality)
7. citizen (citizen)
8. election (election)